

Creating the right conditions

Strive to create a working environment in which your employees feel contented and fulfilled. You will need to make the workplace physically safe (see p.98–99), and provide sufficient lighting and heating for the cooler months.

Develop a culture in which employees flourish and look forward to coming to work (see pp.162–163). This does not mean there should be no rules or discipline; people understand these must exist, as long as they can see the purpose of them. Aim to create an environment where each person feels genuinely satisfied with their work and the way in which they are managed.

LEGAL RESPONSIBILITIES

Although the specific details may differ around the world, employers in most countries have legal responsibilities for the health and well-being of their employees (see pp.212–215). These typically include:

- › **Undertaking an assessment** of any potential risks to people working in the company.
- › **Preparing a health and safety** policy stating what will be done to make the workplace safe.
- › **Having a suitably equipped** first-aid kit and ensuring everyone knows where it is.
- › **Assessing employees' risk** of workplace stress and taking action to prevent them from becoming overly anxious.

Expectations



Most people find it stressful if things are unclear or if they are unsure of what is expected of them. Set out clear aims, carefully selected goals to motivate people, and give them a sense of how they are contributing to the success of the business. Set up regular briefings to keep them informed of their progress.

Listen



Get to know your employees individually. Talk to them and listen to what they say. In this way, you not only show that you value their unique contributions to your business, but you will also be able to sense more quickly when something is wrong. Make sure that no one is afraid to talk to you.

IDENTIFYING STRESS AT WORK

Stress leading to anxiety is a major problem in the workplace, so be alert for these signs. Be prepared to talk to individuals if you think they may have a problem.

- › **Increased absences** People have time off work for various reasons, but taking more time off than normal or arriving late may be a sign of anxiety.
- › **Withdrawing** Those who are anxious may isolate themselves, avoid engaging with others, and prefer to be quiet and alone.
- › **Becoming overemotional** If an individual is moody, argumentative, or reacting in a way that is out of character, it is worth investigating.
- › **Working long hours** A heavy workload might pressurize people to work longer hours than usual or fail to take adequate breaks during the day.